From Museum to your closets, the Dhalapathara revival story!

https://youtu.be/tloFXogrOxw?si=54MmTeIlBbVn3JTR

About Dhalapathara:

Dhalapathara has a glorious history, and hopefully a brilliant future. The documented history for this weave, takes us back a few centuries to a village dominated by the "Rangani" community (entry no. 48 in Central OBC list) in Khurdha district of Odisha.

The community "Rangani" wove a particular type of cloth woven without any jala, jacquard or dobby. 'Rang' means colour and 'Ani' means to bring. "Rangani" added colour to our lives through their woven sarees. To weave such cloth with jacquard would require 400-600 hooks but the Dhalapathara weavers weave it with the help of 'Chiari'. The fabric was woven with the help of warp rib structures or wooden planks known as 'Chiari'. It's a rare weaving technique in extra weft shedding and picking. (Photos 1&2: Leesa Mohanty, Founder, Nirguna showing the more than a hundred year old saree shared with us during video documentation by Nirguna Trust)

When it came to be the best saree for a bride or festivals, Dhalapathara used to be the first choice. This saree got its name from the place of its origin. Its fame was at peak from late 1800s to mid 1900s. During our discussion with Shri Budhinath Prusty, now in his late 90s, he proudly shared how he was a regular at Bhubaneswar weekly market during 1950s and that the traders from Kolkata used to drool over the Dhalapathara sarees. It was a bridal saree then.

The art of Dhalapathara is beautiful and even more beautiful is its history. Some designs of these sarees are Kusumi Kapta, Kankana Pedi, Muktapunji, Nahati and Akata. The designs were extremely sharp and so accurate that it seems impossible that these sarees are made by hand. These weavers were so skilled that they can create exquisite designs without the use of any graph. The weft rib effect gave the beautiful multicolour effect.

Dhalapathara weave has its own sufferings too. The machine operated handlooms took away the demand and jobs of the weavers. These looms could make more sarees in lesser time and were easy to weave. The Dhalapathara saree, once a bridal saree was lost in time. However, Ganesh Pujari ji and Udayanath Sahu reinvented and designed the craft respectively as "Parda" or curtain. With the onset of mechanized handloom machines, when Dhalapathara weavers were struggling for living, they started to weave pardas and created beautiful designs of Lord Krishna, Lord Hanuman, Taj Mahal, sunset scenery, Gautam Buddha, Map of India and several other famous personalities. These pardas were beautiful and so their demand did rise. This art is more than just art, it's a way of living life deep dived in colours. Again with passage of time and less consumer demand, the Dhalapathara Parda is going to be extinct. We had the opportunity of meeting and working with the only parda weaver Shri Braja Bandhu Rout in Dhalapathara today. Even at the age of 75, he continues to weave parda and says the future is dark.

Nirguna's journey in reviving Dhalapathara:

Nirguna Trust is proud to work with Shri Suresh Rout, a highly talented and skilled weaver. We are thankful to Mr. Jitendra Kumar Prusty for introducing Nirguna to this promising weaver from Dhalapathara, Odisha. Shri Rout is one of the only authentic weaver as of today (26 June, 2017) in Dhalapathara.

Nirguna's journey in reviving Dhalapathara has been challenging in many ways. We knew we were entering a zone of no weaver narration as the saree was lost in the early 1900s. It was literally like picking pieces from scratch. Leesa, Founder, Nirguna Trust and a small team of Nirguna field executives started visiting Dhalapathara often and enquiring. We made many trips and knocking at almost every door. But, even then there was no clue about the Dhalapathara Saree. First few months were very disappointing.

Leesa Mohanty, Founder, Nirguna simultaneously started engaging with traders, saree shops, emporiums in Cuttack & Bhubaneswar selling so called "Dhalapathara" sarees. It was evident that the sarees sold in the markets then followed the "Dhalapathara" design but NOT the technique. Leesa continued meeting senior experts in the handloom sector to know more about the weave and started collecting secondary literature.

Finally, during one of the trips after more than five months, Mr. Bansidhar Raut, a manufacturer/ trader confirmed that his father, Shri Sridhar Rout, is willing to weave again and thus started the journey of getting the authentic Dhalapathara saree back on the loom. The raw material sourcing was fully financed by Nirguna and we placed our first order for twenty five sarees with the weaver. It was a moment of jubilation!

Unfortunately, due to ill health of Mr Sridhar Rout the project came to a standstill within a few weeks.

With renewed fever, Nirguna team started spreading the word in the weaving community in Bhubaneswar. We had heard during our initial trips to Dhalapathara that many weavers have moved to the city as roadside vendors or tea stall owners. We again began our Dhalapathara trips and fortunately within a few weeks we met Mr. Jitendra Kumar Prusty. He was a strong link whom we kept in touch with and he finally introduced us to Shri Suresh Rout, a weaver par excellence who was willing to weave the original Dhalapathara saree. However, he was scared of leaving his job in a powerloom in Maharastra. He left his village almost twenty two years back as he could not support his family with the earnings from his loom. Leesa Mohanty, Founder, Nirguna Trust took the responsibility of giving whatever price the weaver expected for the saree. And a commitment to support Mr. Suresh Rout. Mr. Suresh started weaving at his friend's place. Dhalapathara saree was back to the loom for second time within a span of 6 months. Nirguna Trust then provided financial support and now Mr. Suresh Rout has built one extra room with two new looms. Leesa is continuously giving design inputs and trying to promote traditional motifs and designs. With every passing day, Mr. Suresh Rout is making new and intricate designs.

Nirguna Trust focuses on documentation of weaves and crafts of India. Thus, began the video documentation of the Dhalapathara cluster including weaving process in greater detail. The Trust has been since making short video films for promotion of Dhalapathara.

As Leesa Mohanty, Founder, Nirguna says, "Putting Dhalapathara back on the national handloom map has been challenging but an exciting journey for Nirguna. Identifying the weavers, picking up the lost craft, financing and creating forward linkages gives us the courage to contribute in little ways to our national heritage. I must also say revival of the original weaving technique of "Dhalapathara" has been rewarding in many ways. The saree that was lost a century back is being woven again. We at Nirguna feel blessed to have motivated and supported talented weavers of Dhalapathara to pick this weave again. As of today, there are more weavers who want to weave Dhalapathara saree. There is hope and excitement among the weavers in 40s/50s who want to get back to the loom. We are keeping our fingers crossed".

The Technique:

The thread yarns are purchased and are arranged individually and paralleled for facilitating the next step known as winding. In the winding process, charkhas are used for bobbing and prim for wrapping and wefts respectively.

The beam used in Dhalapathara weaves is made up of wood and a required number of rounds of thread are wrapped and wound around the beam. The loom is arranged such that the wrap beam is parallel to the cloth beam. The cloth beam and the wrap beam are then rotated and unwound respectively by hands after a small piece of cloth is weaved. For the making of designs, wooden rectangular chiaris are used. Depending upon the design color and effects, different weft ribs are formed in shedding using the chiaris. After wrapping and looming the wrap, a small cloth is weaved to start the weaving process and make the loom in running. Then, chiaris are inserted in the wrap dividing the threads as per the requirement of different designs. Depending upon the intensity of the design, a varying number of chiaris can be used. The chiaris are kept at 90degrees to each other creating a tension between the wrap and are brought back when the weft is done. The wefts are done by the help of handmade treadles. This process is repeated throughout the fabric. The same designs are repeated to give sarees a symmetrical look.

For picking up the thread from ground for creating the extra wefts, treadles and handmade wooden ground picks are used. Extra wefts are inserted as per the designs in the minds of weavers. Some weavers also take help of graphs to weave a particular design with proper accuracy. The weaver uses just CHIARIS to weave such a single repetition design that otherwise requires at least 400 hooks, jacquard or jalas. On the horizontal bottom panels, small designs of butti like Fishes, flowers etc. are weaved making the aesthetics of the sarees even more beautiful.